

WEST BENGAL

THE TEESTA TUSSLE

By Romita Datta

The vexed issue of sharing the waters of the Teesta river between India and Bangladesh has always been a hot topic during polls for over a decade, especially in the eastern neighbour. Despite that, it has defied resolution. Now, possibly the most contentious issue between the two nations has again assumed significance in a trifecta of polls: Bangladesh prime minister Sheikh Hasina has a general election to face in 2023 and her Indian counterpart Narendra Modi has the Lok Sabha polls to contend with in 2024. Between them stands the high-octane figure of West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee, who is gearing up for the 2023 panchayat elections, besides the general election.

At the end of her four-day trip to India from September 5 to 8, the Bangladesh PM took home seven MoUs on areas like railways, energy, science and technology, media and sharing of waters of the less contentious Kushiyara river flowing through Assam and Bangladesh, which would benefit lower Assam and Sylhet (in Bangladesh). However, not a word flowed on the Teesta agreement. Even while tip-toeing on the Teesta issue during formal declarations, in an interview to a private channel, Hasina made no bones about how India must 'show generosity'.

The Teesta originates in the Tso Lhamo lake in north Sikkim and flows through Sikkim (172 km) and West Bengal (118 km), before entering Bangladesh. Besides the plains of Sikkim, it is vital to several north Bengal districts. Equally vitally, millions of people depend on the 124 km stretch of the river in north Bangladesh, before it meets the Brahmaputra (Jamuna). In either country, the matter of sharing its water is tied to political compulsion. A Teesta water-sharing arrangement was made in 1983 but never implemented. A plan was hammered out in 2011, when then UPA PM, Manmohan Singh, and Hasina agreed to a 40:40 sharing of the waters. But since water is a state subject, Mamata's assent was essential, and she has stood firm in opposing it ever since. The BJP's Bengal unit, too, is in a fix, for the party's electoral success in Bengal is hinged on its growing footprint in north Bengal where, in 2019, the party secured seven out of eight LS seats. In 2021, even in the midst of a Mamata storm, it won 30 out of 54 assembly seats. A Trinamool Congress Rajya Sabha MP says, "Bangladesh has been insisting on

A RIVER WE ALL NEED

- The Teesta flows through Sikkim, N. Bengal and Bangladesh; millions of lives depend on it. Its flow in winter falls drastically
- Being a lower riparian state, Bangladesh bears the brunt of the dry season. It demands an equitable sharing of the Teesta waters
- A 40:40 Teesta water-sharing deal was finalised in 2011, but never signed due to opposition from W. Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee